

Before the
FEDERAL MARITIME COMMISSION
Washington, DC 20573
Docket No. 24-07
TZ SSE Buyer, LLC v. CMA CGM S.A.



VERIFIED AMENDED COMPLAINT

I. INTRODUCTION

1. Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC (“Complainant”), by its undersigned counsel, brings this Verified Amended Complaint against Respondent CMA CGM, S.A. (“CMA” or “Respondent”), pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41301 to seek reparations for injuries to Impact Products, LLC and Safety Zone, LLC (the “Injured Parties”) caused by CMA’s violations of the Shipping Act of 1984, as amended, 46 U.S.C. Sections 40101 *et seq.* (the “Shipping Act”), alleged herein.

2. The Injured Parties originally filed the Verified Complaint against CMA on February 14, 2024. However, on May 21, 2024, the Injured Parties filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy in the United States Bankruptcy Court for the District of Delaware, Case No. 24-bk-11055 (Bankr. Del.) (the “Bankruptcy Proceeding”). As part of the Bankruptcy Proceedings, the Injured Parties sold all of their assets, including the claims asserted against CMA in this case, to Complainant. The Bankruptcy Court approved the sale on July 10, 2024. As a result, the Complainant now brings these claims on behalf of the Injured Parties.

3. Since the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic, global ocean carriers, including CMA, have, as alleged herein, and upon information and belief, unjustly and unreasonably exploited customers, such as the Injured Parties, by vastly increasing their profits at the expense

of shippers and the U.S. public generally, which bears increased freight cost in the form of inflation.

4. As alleged further below, beginning in 2021 through 2022 (the “Relevant Period”), CMA assessed demurrage, detention, per diem, and yard storage charges (the “Charges”) to the Injured Parties for periods of time in which the Injured Parties’ ability to pick up containers at the ports, or return empty containers promptly, was significantly constrained due to circumstances outside of the Injured Parties’ control, such as congestion at ports and shortage of equipment.

5. CMA’s conduct, as alleged herein, with respect to the receipt, handling, storage, and/or delivery of the Injured Parties’ property occurred on a normal and customary basis.

II. THE COMPLAINANT & INJURED PARTIES

6. The Injured Parties Impact Products, LLC and Safety Zone, LLC were corporations with offices in Ohio, Tennessee, and Connecticut, among other locations. Impact Products LLC was located at 2840 Centennial Rd., Toledo, OH 43617 and they had an email address of Thomas.russo@supplysourceglobal.com. Safety Zone LLC had an address of 385 Long Hill Rd., Guilford, CT 06437 and an email address of Thomas.russo@supplysourceglobal.com. Their parent corporation was Supply Source Enterprises (“Supply Source”). The Injured Parties were “shippers” pursuant to 46 U.S.C. 40102(23). Impact Products LLC was the leading manufacturer of supplies and accessories for the cleaning industry, and Safety Zone LLC manufactured safety equipment and products. They were in business for over fifty years. Impact Products LLC was formed in 1963 and Safety Zone LLC in 1973. The Injured Parties had service centers in Connecticut, Ohio, and Shanghai, China and distribution centers in Connecticut, Indiana, California, Texas, and Florida.

7. Complainant is a Delaware limited liability company located at 2840 Centennial Drive, Toledo, Ohio 43617 and has an email address of tlondo@tranzonic.com.

III. THE RESPONDENT

8. Upon information and belief, CMA is a company existing under the laws of France with its principal place of business located at Blvd. Jacques Saade 4, Quasi d' Arenc, 13225 Marseilles, Cedex 02 , France, acting in the United States by and through its agent, CMA CGM (America) LLC, a limited liability company existing under the laws of New Jersey with offices located at 1 CMA CGM Way, Norfolk VA 23502 USA. CMA is a global ocean carrier that offers container transportation and serves multiple ports in the United States.

9. Upon information and belief, Respondent CMA CGM, S.A and its agent CMA CGM (America) LLC acted jointly in the conduct alleged herein with respect to Complainant and, upon information and belief, other shippers, and therefore are referred to herein collectively as “CMA.”

IV. JURISDICTION AND LEGAL AUTHORITY

10. The Federal Maritime Commission (“FMC”) has jurisdiction over this Verified Complaint pursuant to 26 U.S.C. §§ 41301 through 41309.

11. The FMC has personal jurisdiction over CMA as an ocean common carrier, as that term is defined by 46 U.S.C. Section 40102(18), that has entered into a “service contract”, as that term is defined by 46 U.S.C. Section 40102(21), with Laufer Group International (“Laufer”).

12. CMA’s actions alleged herein constitute failures by CMA to establish, observe, and enforce just and reasonable practices relating to receiving, handling, storing, and delivering the property of the Injured Parties, in violation of 46 U.S.C. Section 41102(c) and the FMC’s Interpretive Rule on Demurrage and Detention under the Shipping Act, 85 Fed. Reg. 29,638 (May

18, 2020 (partially codified at 46 C.F.R. Section 545.5) (the “Interpretive Rule”), and in particular the Incentive Principle articulated in the Interpretive Rule.

13. CMA’s assessment of the Charges or a substantial majority thereof, and the alleged acts and omissions of CMA that led to the assessment of such Charges, also constitute violations of 46 U.S. Section 41104, including 46 U.S.C. Section 41104(a)(10)’s prohibition on unreasonable refusals to deal or negotiate.

V. ALLEGED FACTS

14. For the period of 2021 through 2022, the Injured Parties used Laufer, a non-vessel operating common carrier (“NVOCC”), to assist in delivering containers with the Injured Parties’ goods (the “Relevant Containers”) from outside the United States to the United States. Upon information and belief, Laufer entered into a service contract or service contracts with CMA for the shipment of the Relevant Containers on CMA’s vessels. Laufer, as an NVOCC, booked the shipment of the Relevant Containers under these service contracts.

15. Throughout the Relevant Period, the Injured Parties, through Laufer, shipped 132 unique containers using CMA. Of those containers, CMA assessed the Injured Parties with demurrage on 16 containers, detention charges on 5 containers, per diem charges on 52 containers, and yard storage charges on 14 containers. The total demurrage, detention, per diem, and yard storage charges total \$173,722.

16. Laufer passed the Charges to the Injured Parties with no markups. While Laufer invoiced the Injured Parties for the Charges, it was simply acting as a conduit for the Charges that were assessed by CMA. The Injured Parties subsequently paid Laufer a total of \$173,722 for the Charges assessed by CMA during the Relevant Period. Laufer then used the proceeds it received from the Injured Parties to pay CMA.

17. On April 4, 2024, Laufer assigned the claims alleged herein against CMA to the Injured Parties. A true and correct copy of the Assignment of Claims Agreement between the Injured Parties and Laufer is attached herein as **Exhibit A**.

18. As Commissioner Rebecca F. Dye emphasized in her Final Report from the FMC's Fact Finding Investigation 29, "the Interpretive Rule on Detention and Demurrage promulgated by the Commission pursuant to Fact Finding 28 provides the shipping public with an enforceable principle that the Commission employs to assess the reasonableness of demurrage and detention practices and regulations under the Shipping Act of 1984, as amended."

19. As set forth in the FMC's Interpretive Rule, "the purpose of demurrage and detention are to incentivize cargo movement," and therefore the FMC "will consider in the reasonableness analysis under section 41102(c) the extent to which demurrage and detention are serving their intended purposes as financial incentives to promote freight fluidity."

20. CMA's assessment of the Charges, or a substantial majority thereof, and CMA's acts and omissions that led to the assessment of the Charges, were incapable of incentivizing cargo movement and therefore unreasonable.

21. To maximize container use and port storage space, carriers charge a daily fee to shippers who fail to pick up containers promptly or after the number of free days has expired. Similarly, an importer faces detention charges if it fails to unload a container and return the empty container to the port within the free period.

22. CMA refused to act reasonably by increasing the number of free days available to the Injured Parties to pick up containers with the Injured Parties' goods even though CMA created delays beyond CMA's control.

23. In 2021 and 2022, the volume of shipments entering certain ports surged compared to 2020. Despite this increase, CMA refused to divert shipments to less congested ports and failed to extend the number of free days for the Injured Parties to pick up their goods and to drop off empty containers before it assessed the Charges.

24. The Charges assessed by CMA and paid by the Injured Parties were assessed during periods of time in which such Charges were not just or reasonable because of circumstances outside the control of the Injured Parties and its agents and services providers, such as congestion at ports and shortage of equipment.

25. CMA failed to provide adequate practices and facilities to handle and store CMA's empty containers and also failed to provide adequate facilities for its customers, including the Injured Parties, to return empty containers.

26. Despite that knowledge, CMA continued to accept the Injured Parties' goods for ocean common carriage and for receipt, handling, storage, and/or delivery through the ports.

27. CMA failed to provide reasonable free time for the Injured Parties for containers CMA transported into the ports during the time CMA failed to clear its container backlog.

28. The Charges did not serve, and could not have served, as a financial incentive to promote freight fluidity, but instead operated only as a punitive penalty on the Injured Parties for circumstances over which they and their agents and service providers had little to no control.

29. CMA also failed to provide sufficient detail on its invoices to allow the Injured Parties to understand the reasons for the Charges and to be able to contest the Charges.

30. If not fixed, CMA's unlawful practices will become industry standard and leading to a situation where all global container lines can impose the improper detention and demurrage charges upon shippers because of delays and conditions outside of shippers' control.

VI. CAUSES OF ACTION

COUNT I: VIOLATION OF 46 U.S.C. § 41102(c)

31. Complainant repeats and realleges the allegations above as if fully set forth herein.

32. CMA's assessment of the Charges, and the alleged acts or omissions of CMA that led to the assessment of such Charges, constitutes failures by CMA to establish, observe, and enforce just and reasonable practices relating to receiving, handling, storing, and delivering the Injure Parties' property in violation of 46 U.S.C. Section 41102(c), 46 C.F.R. Section 545.5, and the FMC's Interpretive Rule.

COUNT II: VIOLATION OF 46 U.S.C. § 41104(a)(10)

33. Complainant repeats and realleges each and every allegation above as if fully set forth herein.

34. CMA's assessment of the Charges, and the alleged acts or omissions of CMA that led to the assessment of such Charges, constitutes unreasonable refusal to deal or negotiate with the Injured Parties, in violation of 46 U.S.C. Section 41104(a)(10).

VII. CAUSATION

35. The foregoing alleged illegal acts of CMA directly and proximately injured Complainants, through the Injured Parties, by forcing the Injured Parties to pay the Charges.

VIII. COMPLAINANT'S DAMAGES

36. Complainant, through the Injured Parties, have been, and continue to be, actually and materially injured by each of CMA's continuous illegal conduct in violation of the Shipping Act alleged herein.

37. CMA's violations alleged herein have caused direct and proximate financial damages to Complainant, through the Injured Parties, in an amount already believed to exceed \$150,000, currently accruing, and to be further demonstrated in this proceeding.

IX. PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC respectfully request that the FMC require CMA to answer the charges made in this Verified Amended Complaint and prays for relief from the FMC as follows:

1. An investigation by the FMC of the allegations in this Verified Amended Complaint pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41301(c);
2. An Order, after due investigation pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Sections 41302 and 41303 and a hearing pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41304, finding that CMA has violated 46 U.S.C. Section 41102(c) in connection with its respective receipt, handling, storage, and delivery of the property of Impact Products, LLC and Safety Zone, LLC;
3. An Order requiring CMA to pay Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC reparations for the unlawful conduct alleged herein in an amount to be proven pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41305, with interest pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41305(a), Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC's reasonable attorneys' fees as "the prevailing party" pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41305(e), and any other sum the FMC determines to be proper; and
4. Such other and further orders or relief as the FMC deems just and proper.

X. REQUEST FOR ORAL HEARING

1. Complainants requests an oral hearing in Washington, DC.

Respectfully submitted,

CLARK HILL PLC

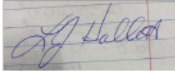
/s/ Timothy R. Herman

Timothy R. Herman
R. Kevin Williams
312.985.5950
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130 E. Randolph Street, Suite 3900
Chicago, IL 60601
Counsel for Complainant TZ SSE Buyer,
LLC

VERIFICATION

I, Larry Hallett, hereby verify as follows:

1. I am Director of Global Logistics for Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC.
2. I am authorized to make this verification on behalf of Complainant TZ SSE Buyer, LLC.
3. I hereby verify that the facts contained in the foregoing Verified Amended Complaint are true and correct to the best of my knowledge, information and belief.
4. I verify the foregoing under penalty of perjury under the laws of the United States.

	
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Larry Hallett, TZ SSE Buyer, LLC

Dated: Sep 20, 2024

EXHIBIT A

ASSIGNMENT OF CLAIMS AGREEMENT

This Assignment of Claims Agreement (the “Agreement”) is made and entered into as of the ___ day of April, 2024 (the “Effective Date”), by and between Laufer Group International, a New York corporation, with offices at 20 Vesey St., Suite 601, New York, NY 10007 (the “Assignor”), and Impact Products, LLC and Safety Zone, LLC (collectively the “Assignees”). Each of the foregoing may sometimes hereinafter be referred to as a “Party” or collectively as the “Parties”).

RECITALS

WHEREAS, on February 14, 2024, Assignees filed verified complaints (the “Complaints”) against the following respondents (collectively referred to as the “Respondents”) in the Federal Maritime Commission (collectively referred to as the “Administrative Proceedings”):

1. Docket No. 24-05 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. Mediterranean Shipping Company SA, Respondents*;
2. Docket No. 24-06 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. Lihua Logistics Company, Respondents*;
3. Docket No. 24-07 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. Overseas Container Line Limited and OOCL (Europe) Limited, Respondents*;
4. Docket No. 24-08 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. CMA CGM S.A., Respondent*;
5. Docket No. 24-09 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. COSCO Shipping Lines Co., Ltd., Respondents*; and
6. Docket No. 24-10 – *Impact Products, LLC et al., Complainants v. Yang Ming Marine Transport Corp., Respondent*

WHEREAS, as part of their Complaints, the Assignees allege that Respondents violated the Shipping Act by assessing demurrage, detention, per diem, and other charges (the “Charges”) to Assignees, and seek damages from Respondents pursuant to 46 U.S.C. Section 41305 (the “Claims”).

WHEREAS, certain disputes have arisen in some of the Administrative Proceedings relating to who—Assignee or Assignor—may bring the claims alleged in the Complaint (“the Dispute”).

WHEREAS, to resolve the Dispute, the Parties desire that Assignor assign to Assignee, and Assignee assume from Assignor, all of Assignor’s right, title, interest, cause or causes of action arising from the Administrative Proceedings and to bring claims for damages against the Respondents listed for demurrage, detention, per diem, and other charges.

NOW, THEREFORE, in consideration of the foregoing, the mutual promises herein contained herein, the receipt and sufficiency of which is hereby acknowledged by the Parties intending to be legally bound by this Agreement, agree as follows:

1. Recitals Incorporated. The Recitals set forth above are incorporated into and made a part of this Agreement.

2. Assignment of the Claims to Assignee. Assignor hereby irrevocably sells, conveys, transfers and assigns to Assignees, and Assignees hereby assume from Assignor, any and all of Assignor's rights, title, interest, claims, cause or causes of action of any kind whatsoever which Assignor has, or may have, arising from the Administrative Proceedings (the "Claims"). This assignment shall be deemed an absolute and unconditional assignment of the Claims.

3. Release of Assignor in Full. If, and only if, Assignor strictly complies with all of its obligations under this Agreement without default beyond notice and opportunity to cure hereunder, then Assignees, for and on behalf of themselves, their agents, affiliates, insiders, employees, attorneys, accountants, successors, assigns, and insurers (collectively, the "Assignee Releasors") shall thereafter fully and completely remise, release and forever discharge Assignors and their respective agents, employees, attorneys, accountants, successors, assigns, and insurers (collectively "Assignor Released Parties") of and from any and all actions, causes of action, demands, debts, suits, sums of money, accounts, bonds, bills, covenants, contracts, controversies, agreements, promises, damages, judgments, deficiency judgments of any kind, assessments, liabilities, losses, obligations, expenses (including attorneys' fees, interest and costs), claims and demands whatsoever, in law or in equity, whether known or unknown, matured or unmatured, that Assignees' Releasors ever had, now have, shall or may have or hereinafter attempt to assert against Assignor that arise from or are related to the Assignees' Complaints, the Claims and the Adversary Proceedings as defined above.

~~4. Release of Assignee in Full. If, and only if, Assignor strictly complies with all of its obligations under this Agreement without default beyond notice and opportunity to cure hereunder, then Assignees, for and on behalf of themselves, their agents, affiliates, insiders, employees, attorneys, accountants, successors, assigns, and insurers (collectively, the "Assignee Releasors") shall thereafter fully and completely remise, release and forever discharge Assignors and their respective agents, employees, attorneys, accountants, successors, assigns, and insurers (collectively "Assignor Released Parties") of and from any and all actions, causes of action, demands, debts, suits, sums of money, accounts, bonds, bills, covenants, contracts, controversies, agreements, promises, damages, judgments, deficiency judgments of any kind, assessments, liabilities, losses, obligations, expenses (including attorneys' fees, interest and costs), claims and demands whatsoever, in law or in equity, whether known or unknown, matured or unmatured, that Assignees' Releasors ever had, now have, shall or may have or hereinafter attempt to assert against Assignor that arise from or are related to the Assignees' Complaints, the Claims and the Adversary Proceedings as defined above.~~

5. Representations and Warranties. The Assignor and each Assignee represents and warrants to the other that:

- a. it has not assigned, subrogated, or transferred or purported to assign, subrogate, or transfer, to any person, firm, partnership, corporation or entity whatsoever any action(s) or cause(s) of action at law or in equity, suits, debts, demands, claims,

contracts, covenants, liens, liabilities, losses, costs, accounts, expenses (including, without limitation attorneys' fees), or damages released in this Agreement; and

b. it has full power and authority to execute and perform its obligations under this Agreement in all respects; and

c. execution and delivery of this Agreement and the performance of each Party's obligations hereunder and thereunder have been authorized by all necessary action and do not violate any laws, regulations or orders by which each Party is bound; and

d. this Agreement constitutes each Party's legal, valid and binding obligations, enforceable against each Party in accordance with the terms hereof and thereof.

e. Assignor further represents and warrants that (i) Assignor is the true and lawful owner of the Claims; (ii) Assignor has made no prior assignment or sale of the Claims; (iii) the execution and delivery of this Agreement by Assignor and the assignment of all its right, title, and interest in the Claims does not contravene any agreement to which Assignor is a party or by which it is bound; and (iv) no liens, encumbrances, charges, security interests or obligations of any kind exist on the date hereof against the Claims.

6. Review by Counsel. The Parties acknowledge that they have each had the opportunity and/or have had this Agreement reviewed by independent counsel of their choice, and further represent that they are competent to enter into this Agreement, fully understand its terms and consequences, and enter into it knowingly and voluntarily.

7. Choice of Law/Venue. The Parties hereto agree that the terms of this Agreement shall be interpreted and construed pursuant to the laws of the State of Illinois, without regard to choice of law.

8. Notices. All notices or other communications required under this Agreement shall be in writing and shall be deemed to have been duly given and received (a) the third Business Day after mailing by first-class certified or registered mail, return receipt requested and postage prepaid; or (b) the following Business Day after mailing by a nationally recognized overnight courier service for next Business Day delivery and charges prepaid; or (c) the same Business Day if sent by electronic mail prior to 5:00 CT (the following Business Day if sent after 5:00 CT) and proof of such email delivery can be reasonably established, and in all instances addressed as follows:

TO ASSIGNEES:

c/o Clark Hill PLC

130 E. Randolph St., Suite 3900

Chicago, IL 60601

Attn: Timothy R. Herman (therman@clarkhill.com)

TO ASSIGNOR:

Laufer Group International
20 Vesey St #601
New York, NY 10007

9. Continuing Cooperation. If at any time after the date hereof, either Party reasonably determines that additional action (including, without limitation, the execution and delivery of further documents and other instruments) is necessary to carry out the purposes of this Agreement, such party will so notify the other Party, who agrees to take the requested further action. Thereafter, the Assignor shall execute, acknowledge and deliver all such further assignments, sales, transfers, conveyances, warranties, licenses, applications, notices and assumptions and such other instruments, and shall take or cause to be taken such further actions, as may be reasonably necessary or appropriate to make effective the transactions contemplated by this Agreement.

10. Third Party Beneficiary. This Agreement is entered into for the sole protection and benefit of the Parties hereto and their respective successors and assigns, and no other person shall be a direct or indirect beneficiary of, or shall have any direct or indirect cause of action or claim in connection with this Agreement, nor is anything in this Agreement intended to relieve or discharge the obligation or liability of any third persons to any party to this Agreement.

11. Successors and Assigns. This Agreement and the representations and warranties, covenants and agreements herein contained shall inure to the benefit of and shall bind the respective Parties hereto and their respective successors and assigns.

12. Severability. If any clause or provision of this Agreement is determined to be illegal, invalid or unenforceable under any present or future law by the final judgment of a court of competent jurisdiction, the remainder of this Agreement will not be affected thereby. It is the intention of the Parties that if any such provision is held to be illegal, invalid or unenforceable, there will be added in lieu thereof a provision as similar in terms to such provision as is possible and be legal, valid and enforceable.

13. Entire Agreement. This Agreement is intended to embody the final, complete and exclusive agreement among the Parties with respect to the subject matter hereof and is intended to supersede all prior agreements, understandings and representations written or oral, with respect thereto; and may not be contradicted by evidence of any such prior or contemporaneous agreement, understanding or representation, whether written or oral.

14. Amendments. This Agreement shall not be altered, modified or amended except by a written instrument signed by each of the parties hereto.

15. Counterparts. This Agreement may be executed in multiple counterparts, each of which shall be deemed an original, but all of which together shall constitute one and the same Agreement.

[SIGNATURES CONTINUED ON FOLLOWING PAGE]

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, the Parties have executed this document on the dates set forth below:

**ASSIGNOR, LAUFER GROUP
INTERNATIONAL**

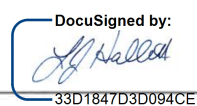
By: 

Name: Brian Martorano

Title: National Director, Ocean Impact

Dated: 4/3/2024

**ASSIGNEES, IMPACT PRODUCTS,
LLC AND SAFETY ZONE, LLC**

By: 

Name: Lawrence Hallett

Title: Director, Global Logistics

Dated: 4/4/2024